expanding settlements in the occupied territories. Then came the first Lebanon war (particularly the Sabra and Shatila massacre) and the first intifada, shattering what Vorspan called the "romantic idealization" of Israel. "Now Israel reveals itself, a nation like all the others," he added in his diary. "Welcome to Israel's Vietnam, Kent State and Watts rolled into one. What did we expect? An eternity of Golda Meir and 'the woman of valor,' *kibbutzniks* dancing the *hora* around bonfires?" *Aliyah* rates fell, and eventually settled around 2,500 people per year, less than a tenth of a per cent of the population. The formal Jewish and pro-Israel community fragmented, with the rise of groups like J Street, the center-left alternative to AIPAC, and Jewish Voice for Peace, which supports a boycott of Israeli settlements.

As Dov Waxman wrote in *Trouble in the Tribe*, his 2016 survey of the relationship, "the consensus about Israel that prevailed within the American Jewish community in the 1960s and 1970s has long since disappeared."

Another myth—in essence a canard, repeated by both anti-Semites and some of Israel's strongest advocates—is that American Jews consider Israel a political issue of paramount importance. A 2016 survey by the American Jewish Committee found that just 10 per cent of American Jews chose foreign policy as the most important issue in the presidential election. Some 12 per cent ranked it as the second-most important. The economy, health care, and national security all received a larger share of the vote.

Still, we can make two sweeping generalizations about American Jewish attitudes toward Israel. The first is that, for all the talk of growing alienation, most American Jews still retain warm feelings for the Jewish state. A wide-ranging 2013 Pew poll found that 69 per cent of American Jews feel an emotional attachment to Israel. There is a notable generation gap—60 per cent of millennial Jews answered yes, compared to 79 per cent of senior citizens—but a majority from almost every Jewish demographic feels that connection.[6]

The survey also found, however, that 57 per cent of American Jews have never been to the country. Few of those who do visit can fully engage with the culture, since 83 per cent cannot hold a conversation in Hebrew. Which leads to the second conclusion: most American Jews are attached to an imaginary Israel.

The average American Jew, after all, is a secular liberal. They vote Democratic in larger numbers than almost any other demographic group;